

Fig. 2: Scope of Automotive Skill Development Council

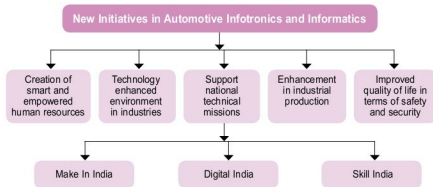


Fig. 3: New initiatives in automotive infotronics and informatics

There is considerable speculation that traditional telephony, which is now largely digital, will transform and Voice over Internet Protocol, or VoIP, would come into the picture by virtue of which people would not only communicate via the Internet but also take any other kind of services.

We saw the coming of Global Positioning System (GPS), which provides mobile phones with pinpoint geographic locations. Therefore even if automobiles are not embedded with such systems like automobile electronics, just by connecting our mobile devices in a slot, digital mobile telephony can become a tool by which every vehicle on the road becomes a part of the network of communication and entertainment. All credit goes to IT, which is the heart of these recent advancement in communication in automobiles arena.

Marketing, motivational, financial issues and awareness. IT and its recent developments have played a crucial role in this arena of marketing of automobiles and their outreach to people. It focuses mainly on produc-

tion and distribution of vehicles and remarketing of used vehicles. Most enthusiastically discussed areas of IT applications to automobiles in recent years have been in the chain of marketing and distribution. OEMs have constructed their own IT based coordination mechanisms for supply chains over the years. Application of IT to marketing and distribution can be summarised as:

- Websites provide purchase-related information to buyers for purchasing an automobile of their choice by giving a platform for comparison between various models on the grounds of engine, interior design, outlook, comfort, transmission, speed and so on. It is all possible via World Wide Web (www) in addition to the above-mentioned facilities, which provide a base for price negotiation.

- Although it is a matter of great loss to dealers who might try to fool innocent buyers, it is a boon in disguise for buyers. Just sitting at their homes, offices or parks, they can order the product of their choice at a justified price.

- Services like *Auto-by-Tel.com* make it possible for customers to be in touch with the dealers of a wide variety of automobiles. Others include *ForeDirect.com* and *AutoNation.com*. It is therefore expected that this area of application will become more important in the future and will take the concept of automotive informatics to the apex altogether. Websites like *cardekho.com*, *carwale.com* and *quickrcars.com* help customers to opt for various options to get the right product in the right budget.

Educational initiatives

A pool of open electives in the field of automobiles that should be introduced at the under-graduate level for all engineering branches can be broadly formulated as:

- Automotive informatics
- Automotive electronics
- Automotive design
- Energy-efficient techniques
- Smart electronics

A student pursuing branches other than mechanical or automobile can get exposure to recent trends in automobile as well as to its application areas. Moreover, it will prove to be a stepping stone for employment opportunities in automotive electronics/informatics industries.

When an under-graduate student opts for an elective, he/she would feel comfortable to pursue an interdisciplinary master's course in India and abroad. It could be automotive design, smart systems or a subject of his/her choice.

Interest of a student studying in any branch may not be directly related to mechanical/automobile sector, but these electives will safeguard the interest of applied branches to find a narrow area to apply the core subject knowledge to contribute to smart automobile sectors.

Educational institutes hesitate to introduce such courses/electives as they may need to appoint faculties/experts for this initiatives. But the solution is very simple